Currency Conversion — Which Service Should We Use?

Simple recommendation for Lead / Project Manager · Based on our test app (website + server)

What is this about? (in plain words)

When a user types an amount in Indian Rupees (INR) — or another local currency — our product needs to show the same amount in another currency such as US Dollars (USD), UAE Dirhams (AED), or Saudi Riyals (SAR).

That conversion needs a trustworthy **exchange rate** (how many dollars one rupee is worth). People often call this **currency conversion** or **foreign exchange**. We buy that rate data from an online service (like a weather API, but for money rates).

We also need the rate for a **specific date** the user chooses (for example, the date of an invoice), not only "today's" rate — and we should **save the rate we used** on that record so numbers don't change later.

Reference we compared against

Date: **22 Oct 2026** · Amount: **10,000 INR**

Reference	In US Dollars (USD)	In UAE Dirhams (AED)
Original / expected mid-market	105.43	388.90

Services we researched

We looked at three online services:

1. **Open Exchange Rates** — https://openexchangerates.org/
2. **ExchangeRate-API** — https://www.exchangerate-api.com/
3. **CurrencyAPI / free community feeds** — fine for demos only, not for a company product

Our recommendation

First choice for production: Open Exchange Rates (paid plan).
If budget is tight: ExchangeRate-API (paid plan) — we can switch with a simple setting.

Why we prefer Open Exchange Rates over ExchangeRate-API

- **Past-date rates matter for business.** Paid Open Exchange Rates is stronger when we must convert using the rate on the user's selected date (invoice / booking date), not only today's rate.
- **Better fit for a company product.** It is commonly used by application backends, with a clear paid service model and clearer commercial terms.
- **Easier to keep records straight.** We can fetch a dated rate and store "what rate we used and on which date" on each transaction for audit / support questions later.
- **Works for all currencies we need** (INR, USD, AED, SAR, and more) in one standard approach on the server.
- **Honest trade-off:** ExchangeRate-API looked a bit closer on AED in our quick tests and is usually a little cheaper. We still recommend Open Exchange Rates for production capability; ExchangeRate-API stays the budget backup.

Simple comparison

	Open Exchange Rates	ExchangeRate-API
Best when	Company product + date-based conversion	Lower cost + simple day-to-day convert
Strengths	Past dates, mature paid service, good for saving rates used	Good accuracy in our tests, simpler / often cheaper
Watch-outs	Slightly higher price; double-check AED vs bank if needed	Weaker past-date story on lower plans
Free plan (approx.)	About 1,000 calls / month (mainly today's rates)	About 1,500 calls / month (mainly today's rates)

What we already did in the app

Our test project now defaults to **Open Exchange Rates**. ExchangeRate-API is still available if we decide cost is more important. Free community feeds should not be used for the real company product.

One important business note

For official company accounts / tax in India, we may still need **RBI or bank rates**. Online conversion services are good for the product experience if we save the exact rate used; they may not replace official rates for accounting.

Decision asked: Approve Open Exchange Rates (paid) as primary. Keep ExchangeRate-API as the lower-cost alternative.

Internal review note · written in plain language for non-technical readers